

Southern Spiced Buttermilk Chicken

Crispy strips of chicken served with a fiery dipping mayo

Ingredients

6 large chicken breasts
2 cloves of garlic
1/2 tsp salt
2 tsp soy sauce
1/2 tsp ground black pepper
1 tsp paprika
1 tsp finely chopped fresh thyme
250ml buttermilk

Coating

6 tbsp cake flour
4 tbsp corn flour
3 eggs
300gms golden bread crumbs

Method

Cut the chicken into equal sized strips. Now in a large bowl and all the remaining ingredients for the chicken to the buttermilk. Add the chicken strips to the buttermilk mixture and set aside for about 20-minutes

Whilst the chicken is in the marinade prepare your mayonnaise.

To prepare the fry coating, place the eggs in a flat bowl, and whisk lightly. In a second dish add the cornflour, flour and season well with salt and pepper. In a third dish add the bread crumbs.

In a large frying pan add enough sunflower oil to shallow fry the chicken strips. Place the oil over a medium high heat, once the oil is almost ready start to prepare your chicken strips.

Remove each strip of chicken from the marinade, and gently lay them one at a time into the flour mixture, Dust generously on both sides and then dip into the egg wash before pressing gently into the bread crumbs. If the strips have too much buttermilk you can remove a little with your fingers.

To test the oil is ready add a few bread crumbs, they should fizzle. Now carefully add the strips one at a time into the hot oil, allow time for the strip to brown before turning and finishing cooking. Place the strips of some paper towel before keeping warm in the oven. Serve with the hot dipping mayo.

Fiery Dipping Mayo

Ingredients

8 Tablespoons good mayo
2 Tablespoon chili sauce, Tabasco or any chili hot sauce
2 teaspoon lemon/lime juice
1/2 teaspoon soy sauce (optional)

Directions:

1. In bowl, whisk together the ingredients until smooth.
2. Use as dip or spread for your favorite dishes.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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Chocolate Brownies

INGREDIENTS

240g butter, melted and cooled
2 tablespoon vegetable oil
150g brown sugar
200g white sugar
4 large eggs, room temperature
2 teaspoons vanilla extract
150g all purpose flour
120g good quality, unsweetened cocoa powder
1 teaspoon salt
100g roughly chopped chocolate or large chocolate chips
100g roasted, blanched hazelnuts
Zest of 1 orange

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1

Preheat the oven to 175°C then line a 7x11 inch baking tray with parchment paper and set aside.

Step 2

In a large bowl combine melted butter, oil and both sugars. Add the eggs, vanilla, orange peel and salt then whisk for about one minute until evenly combined and light in color.

Step 3

Over the same bowl sift in the flour and cocoa powder. Gently fold the dry ingredients into the wet ingredients until JUST combined (do NOT over mix). Fold in the chocolate chunks and the hazelnuts.

Step 4

Pour the batter into the prepared pan, then smooth the top.

Step 5

Bake for 35-40 minutes, or until the centre of the brownies no longer jiggles and is JUST set to the touch.

Step 6

Remove from the oven and allow to cool to room temperature before removing from the baking tray and slicing into 16 brownies. Enjoy!

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Spanakopita

1 kg. fresh spinach, washed, dried, trimmed, and coarsely chopped
3 Tbs. extra-virgin olive oil
1 bunch scallions (about 3 oz. or 10 small), white and light-green parts only, trimmed and finely chopped
2 cups crumbled feta cheese (10 oz.)
1/2 cup finely grated Greek kefalotyri cheese or Parmigiano-Reggiano
2 large eggs, lightly beaten
1/2 cup finely chopped fresh dill
1/3 cup finely chopped fresh flat-leaf parsley
1/4 tsp. freshly grated nutmeg
Kosher or fine sea salt

For the assembly:

1/3 cup extra-virgin olive oil for brushing; more as needed
Eighteen 9x14-inch sheets frozen phyllo dough, thawed and at room temperature
2 tsp. milk

TIP:
Phyllo dries out very fast and becomes brittle when exposed to the air. Check out our test kitchen tips for working with it.
Position a rack in the center of the oven and heat the oven to 375°F.

Make the filling: Heat a 10-inch straight-sided saute pan over medium-high heat. Add a few large handfuls of the spinach and cook, tossing gently with tongs. As the spinach starts to wilt, add the rest a few handfuls at a time. Cook until all the spinach is wilted and bright green, about 4 minutes. With a slotted spoon, transfer the spinach to a colander set in a sink. Let cool slightly and squeeze with your hands to extract as much of the remaining liquid as you can.

Wipe the pan dry with a paper towel. Heat the oil in the pan over medium heat. Add the scallions and cook until soft and fragrant, about 4 minutes. Stir in the spinach, turn off the heat, and let cool for 5 minutes. Then stir in the cheeses, eggs, dill, parsley, nutmeg, and 1/2 tsp. salt and mix thoroughly.

Assemble the pie: With a pastry brush, lightly coat the bottom and sides of a 9x13x2-inch baking pan with some of the oil. Working quickly, lightly oil one side of a phyllo sheet and lay it in the pan oiled side up and off center so that it partially covers the bottom and reaches halfway up one long side of the pan (the edge on the bottom of the pan will be about 1 inch from the side). Lightly oil the top of another phyllo sheet and lay it oiled side up and off center so it reaches halfway up the other long side of the pan. (If your pan has sloped sides, the sheets may be slightly longer than the bottom of the pan; if so, let the excess go up one short side of the pan and then alternate with subsequent sheets.) Repeat this pattern with 4 more phyllo sheets.

Next, lightly oil the tops of 3 phyllo sheets and layer them oiled side up and centered in the pan. Spread the filling evenly over the last layer.

Repeat the oiling and layering of the remaining 9 phyllo sheets over the filling in the same way you layered the previous 9. With the oiled bristles of the pastry brush, push the edges of the phyllo down around the sides of the pan to enclose the filling completely.

With a sharp knife, score the top phyllo layer into 24 rectangles, being careful not to cut all the way through to the filling. Using the same pastry brush, brush the milk along all the score marks (this will keep the phyllo from flaking up along the edges of the squares). Bake the spanakopita until the top crust is golden brown, 35 to 45 minutes. Let cool until just warm. Cut out the rectangles carefully along the score marks and serve.

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ULTIMATE GRILLED CHEESE

Ingredients

100g cream cheese, softened
1/4 cup mayonnaise
2 cups cheddar cheese, grated
2 cups parmesan/gruyere/other, grated
1/2 clove garlic finely crushed (optional)
1/2 teaspoon seasoning salt
1/4 teaspoon cracked black pepper
12 slices ciabatta thick sliced
1/2 cup butter, softened, more if needed

Method

1. Blend all ingredients except bread and butter in a medium bowl.
2. Butter one side of each slice of bread.
3. Put sandwiches together using about 1/2 cup of filling each.
4. Place buttered side of bread on the outside of sandwich.
5. Toast on griddle or in skillet until a deep golden brown. Make sure you cook this slowly over low to med-low heat, so that the inside has a chance to melt before the outside gets too done. Kick up the heat when it gets going.

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CRÈME ANGLAISE

INGREDIENTS

1160ml full cream milk
4 tsp pure vanilla extract with seeds
8 large free-range egg yolks
6 tbsp caster sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1

Put the milk in a medium saucepan with the vanilla pod and seeds and slowly bring just up to the boil. Set aside to infuse for 10 minutes. Remove the pod.

Step 2

In a mixing bowl, beat the egg yolks with the sugar using a wooden spoon until well combined. Pour in the infused milk, stirring constantly until well combined.

Step 3

Return the custard to the cleaned pan and heat gently, stirring, for about 5 minutes until it thickens and lightly coats the back of a spoon. Don't let it boil or the yolks will scramble (see tips).

Step 4

When the custard has reached the desired thickness, remove it from the heat and strain through a sieve into a medium bowl. Put a piece of cling film on the surface to prevent a skin forming and set aside or chill until ready to use.

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CREAMED SPINACH

Ingredients

25g butter

1 small onion, finely chopped

2 tbsp plain flour

200ml full-fat milk

400g spinach

100ml single cream

fresh nutmeg, for grating

Method

Step 1

Heat the butter in a saucepan, then add the onion and cook for 5 mins until softened. Stir in the flour and cook for 2 mins, then slowly start to whisk in the milk. When it has all been incorporated, gently cook for 5 mins until the sauce has thickened.

Step 2

Meanwhile, place the spinach in a large pot, add a small splash of water and the cook over a high heat until the spinach has just wilted.

Step 3

Place the wilted spinach in a dish cloth and tightly squeeze until any excess liquid has been removed, then roughly chop. Stir into the sauce, then add the cream, gently heat, finally finely grate over some nutmeg and season well.

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Moules Marinieres

Ingredients

2 tablespoons unsalted butter
1 small leek, white and light green parts only, thinly sliced
1 small shallot, thinly sliced
4 medium cloves garlic, thinly sliced
2 bay leaves
Coarse salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 cup hard dry cider or white wine
1kg mussels, cleaned
2 to 3 tablespoons heavy cream
1 tablespoon juice and 1 teaspoon grated zest from 1 lemon
3 tablespoons minced fresh parsley leaves
Additional homemade mayonnaise for serving (optional, see note above)
1 loaf rustic sourdough bread, thickly sliced, drizzled with olive oil, and broiled until heavily toasted

Method

Step 1:

Melt 1 tablespoon butter in a large saucepan over medium-low heat. Add leeks, shallot, garlic, and bay leave. Season lightly with salt and heavily with black pepper and cook, stirring, until vegetables are very soft but not browned, about 10 minutes.

Step 2:

Increase heat to high and add cider or wine. Bring to a boil and let reduce by half, about 2 minutes. Add mussels, stir, cover, and cook, shaking pan constantly and peeking every 30 seconds to stir. As soon as all the mussels are open, transfer mussels to a bowl using tongs. Place pan lid over bowl to keep mussels warm.

Step 3:

Remove from heat and whisk in remaining butter along with heavy cream. Return mussels to pot, add parsley, lemon juice, and lemon zest, stir to combine, then transfer to a warm serving bowl. Serve immediately.

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TRUFFLED MAC N CHEESE

Ingredients

Macaroni

250 g (elbow pasta)

1 tbsp unsalted butter

Topping:

2/3 cup panko breadcrumbs

2 tbsp unsalted butter

1/4 tsp salt

Sauce:

60 g unsalted butter

1/3 cup plain flour (all purpose flour)

3-4 cups milk, warmed

200g grated cheese (cheddar/gruyere)

100g grated mozzarella cheese, or more other cheese of choice (Note 2)

3/4 tsp salt

Seasonings (optional):

½ tsp mustard powder

1 tsp black truffle paste

100gm pancetta, cut into cubes, and dry fried until crispy

Directions

Preheat oven to 180C/350F.

Pasta:

Bring a large pot of water to the boil. Add macaroni and cook per packet directions MINUS 1 minute.

Drain, return pasta to pot, add butter and toss until melted. Set aside to cool while making the Sauce

Topping:

Mix together Topping. Set aside.

Sauce:

In a large saucepan or in an ovenproof skillet, melt butter over medium heat. Add flour and cook, stirring constantly, for 1 minute.

Add about 1 cup of the milk and mix to dissolve the paste into the milk. Then add remaining milk and mix until lump free (use whisk if required).

Mix in salt and Seasonings if using.

Cook, stirring/whisking regularly, for 5 - 8 minutes until thickened to a cream consistency. When the Sauce coats the back of a wooden spoon, you should be able to draw a path with your finger.

Remove from stove, add the crisp pancetta pieces, truffle paste and cheese and stir - the cheese doesn't need to melt. Taste and adjust salt to taste.

Assembling:

Pour Sauce into pot with Macaroni. Stir quickly, then pour back into the skillet or a baking dish. Sprinkle with breadcrumb topping.

Bake for 25 minutes or until top is light golden. Don't bake too long otherwise you'll bake away the Sauce! Serve immediately!

PEAR, WALNUT SALAD

INGREDIENTS

200g mixed lettuce (arugula, romaine, etc.)

1 ripe pear - unpeeled, cored, sliced

55g walnuts, roughly chopped

55g Pecorino Romano cheese, shaved

Vinaigrette

2 tablespoon white wine vinegar

1/2 teaspoon mustard

1/2 tsp finely minced garlic

6 tablespoons olive oil

METHOD

Step 1

To make the vinaigrette, combine, vinegar, mustard and garlic. Whisk till well combined. While whisking constantly, slowly pour in a steady stream of the olive oil.

Step 2

Prepare the remaining ingredients, toss the vinaigrette with them and serve.

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CHICKEN & SUNDRIED TOMATO SAUSAGE ROLLS

INGREDIENTS

1 kg chicken thighs, deboned and skinless,
minced
1 medium brown onion, chopped finely
1/2 cup breadcrumbs
1 egg
1/4 cup finely chopped fresh basil
1/2 tsp dried oregano
1/2 cup drained semi-dried tomatoes in oil,
finely chopped
2 tbsp tomato paste
5 sheets puff pastry
1 egg, extra to glaze

METHOD

Step 1

Preheat the oven to 220C/200C fan forced. Line oven trays with baking paper

Step 2

Combine mince, onion, breadcrumbs, egg, basil, semi-dried tomato and paste in a large bowl

Step 3

Cut pastry sheets in half lengthways. Place equal amounts of chicken filling mixture along the centre of each pastry piece; roll pastry to enclose the filling

Step 4

Cut each into 6 equal pieces, place seam side down, on trays. Brush with extra egg

Step 5

Bake rolls for about 30-minutes. Serve warm with a home made tomato sauce

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Classic Malva Pudding

Pudding:

60gms butter
1 cup white sugar
2 EXTRA LARGE eggs
2tbsp apricot jam
2tsp bicarbonate of soda
1 cup milk
2 cups cake flour
Pinch of Salt
30ml vinegar

Sauce

250g butter
1 1/2 cups white sugar
1/2 cup water
1 1/2 cups cream
2 tsp vanilla essence

Instructions

Step 1

Cream butter and sugar together, beat in the egg until light and fluffy. Beat in the apricot jam.

Step 2

Dissolve the bicarb in the milk.

Step 3

Sift the flour and salt together and add to the creamed mixture alternately with the milk. Lastly stir in the vinegar.

Step 4

Pour into a deep round dish about 19cm diameter. Cover the dish with a lid or foil and then bake for 1 hour at 180°C.

Sauce

Step 1

Bring the butter, sugar and water to the boil and simmer, stirring all the time for 2 minutes.

Step 2

Remove from the stove and then add the cream and the vanilla. Pour over the hot baked pudding.

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Roasted Pumpkin Soup with Truffles

Ingredients

1.5kg pumpkin
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 head of garlic, cut in half horizontally
handful of rosemary sprigs
olive oil, to drizzle
1½ tbsp olive oil
1 onion, peeled and chopped
pinch of freshly grated nutmeg
30g Parmesan, freshly grated
800ml hot chicken stock
100ml double cream
15g butter

Method

Step 1

For the pumpkin purée, preheat the oven to 170°C. Cut the pumpkin in half horizontally and remove the seeds - save these to make a snack. Score the flesh, season with salt and pepper, then rub with the cut garlic halves. Lay rosemary and thyme sprigs and a garlic half in each pumpkin half. Drizzle with a little olive oil and place on baking trays.

Roast the pumpkin halves for about 1 hour until tender; the timing will depend on the variety, density and thickness. It is ready when you can effortlessly slip a knife into the thickest part of the flesh. Take out the rosemary and garlic; reserve the garlic. While still hot, scoop out the pumpkin flesh and purée in a blender or food processor.

Step 2

For the soup, heat the olive oil in a large saucepan, add the onion and cook for 5–6 minutes until soft and translucent. Scoop out the flesh from 2 or 3 roasted garlic cloves and add to the pan with the nutmeg and a little seasoning. Sauté for a further 1–2 minutes.

Step 3

Stir in the pumpkin purée and Parmesan, then pour in the stock. Bring to the boil, lower the heat and simmer for 10–12 minutes. Stir in the cream and heat for a minute.

In batches, ladle the soup into a blender and blend until smooth. Add the butter and blitz again to a velvety smooth texture.

Step 4

Pour the soup into a clean pan to reheat.

Step 5

Pour the hot soup into warmed bowls and dot with some black truffle paste and some shaved parmesan.

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Fresh Potato Gnocchi

Ingredients:

1kg floury potatoes, medium Nicola are best
3 large eggs, beaten
300g plain flour or less, depending on the texture of the potatoes

Instructions

Step 1

Add the whole potatoes in their skins to a pot of salted boiling water. Bring back to the boil and simmer for 10-15 minutes until just soft (will depend on the size of your potatoes). Test with a knife – the potatoes should be cooked, but not overcooked, otherwise they will be mushy and will have absorbed too much water. Hold them in a dish cloth to peel as they will be hot.

Step 2

Using a mouli/potato ricer/sieve press the potatoes into a bowl or onto a clean work surface. Make a hollow in your pile of potatoes, then pour in the egg and sprinkle over half the flour. Start to blend everything with your hands, adding more flour but as little as you can get away with. Work carefully and quickly, as the more you handle the dough, the harder and bouncier it will become. You need the same lightness you would use for pastry.

You should now have a soft dough that holds together, doesn't feel sticky and can be easily shaped.

Step 3

Divide the dough into 3 equal pieces. Roll a piece at a time into long, thumb-nail thick cylinders on a lightly floured surface, again working lightly and quickly. As you roll you will also be gently stretching the dough. Keep the surface well floured as you don't want the gnocchi to stick.

Step 4

Cut the dough into thumb-nail long lengths. To score the gnocchi use the back of a fork pressed against the gnocchi. This will help to carry the sauce that you use, it is not essential however.

Step 5

Bring a large, deep pot of salted water to the boil. Working with a few at a time, drop in the gnocchi and listen for the wonderful kissing noise they make as they go in. Let them cook for 2 minutes, during which time they will bob back up to the surface, then scoop them out with a slotted spoon. Taste - they should be *soffici e leggeri* (soft and light), the gnocchi equivalent of *al dente*.

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Spicey Chicken & Sundried Tomatoes

Ingredients:

1 tbsp. extra-virgin olive oil
5 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs
2 cloves garlic, minced
1 tbsp. fresh thyme leaves
1 tsp. crushed red pepper flakes
1 tsp sicilian orgeano
3/4 cup chicken broth
1/2 cup heavy cream
1/2 cup chopped sun-dried tomatoes
1/4 cup grated Parmesan
Kosher salt and black pepper
Fresh basil, for serving

Directions:

Step 1

Preheat oven to 180C. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat oil. Add chicken and season with salt and pepper. Sear until golden and skin is crispy, 3 minutes per side. Transfer chicken to a plate and pour off half the fat.

Step 2

To skillet, add garlic, thyme, oregano and crushed red pepper flakes and let cook until fragrant, 1 minute. Add chicken broth, heavy cream, sun-dried tomatoes, and Parmesan and season with salt. Bring to a simmer, then return chicken to skillet and simmer covered, gently for 15 minutes, until chicken is fully cooked through.

Step 3

Garnish with basil and serve.

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Porcini Risotto

Paul Maciel - The Cookery

Serves: 6-8

INGREDIENTS

60gms dried porcini mushrooms
8 cups chicken stock
1/4 cup olive oil
1 medium onion, diced
Salt and pepper
1 clove garlic, diced
2 cups arborio rice
1 cup dry white wine
1 tablespoon flat leaf parsley, chopped
4 tablespoons cold butter
1/2 cup Parmesan, finely grated

1. Soak dried porcini in 3 cups hot water until rehydrated, about an hour. Once mushrooms have soaked carefully lift the larger pieces out, being careful to not disturb the bottom liquid, it may contain fine sand and dust from the mushrooms.
2. Strain the balance of the liquid through a napkin, reserving the broth for the risotto. (If you chose to not filter every last drop then discard the last cm of the liquid; it will contain dirt from the porcini.) Roughly chop the mushrooms, then set aside. When you're ready, heat the chicken stock and mushroom broth to a simmer.
3. Heat the oil in a large saucepan over medium heat; add onion, carrot and celery and season with salt and pepper; add garlic and cook until slightly translucent. Cook until the vegetable mix is cooked and softened but not browned.
4. Now add half of the chopped dried, and soaked, mushrooms. Cook for two or three minutes.
5. Add the rice and stir to coat with the oil; season with salt and pepper and cook until slightly translucent.
6. The rice should be hot and sizzling, you should stir carefully to ensure it does not stick.
7. Add wine to the hot rice, the liquid should hiss and be quickly absorbed. Stir gently until almost all the liquid has cooked off. Add hot stock and broth mixture, a ladleful at a time, completely stirring in the liquid each time. Remember at this stage you are trying to coax the starches out the rice by gently and continuously stirring.
8. Keep adding broth as needed so there is always a 1/2cm liquid layer over the rice.
9. After about 8 minutes add the balance of the soaked mushrooms.
10. After 15 to 20 minutes, the rice should be close to al dente.
11. If you are adding pan fried fresh mushrooms, stir them in at this stage and combine well.
12. Taste and adjust seasoning. Remove from heat and stir in butter, then cheese.
13. Now cover the pan, and allow it to stand for 2-3minutes.

To serve, spoon into shallow bowls, shave some Parmesan on top.

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Pan Fried Wild Mushrooms

Make the most of the earthy flavours of mushroom

Ingredients

250g Portabelini or Wild mushrooms
1 clove garlic, finely minced
2 tbsp butter
3 tbsp olive oil
60ml marsala or sherry
1/4 tsp finely chopped red chili
1 tbsp finely chopped flat leaf parsley
2 tbsp cold butter, cut into pieces

Method

1. In a pan heat the olive oil, butter until bubbling
2. Now add the garlic and chili to the pan
3. Cook for 1-minute, now add the sliced mushrooms (brush and remove tough parts first)
4. Cook the mushrooms for a few minutes, add a little extra olive oil if you need
5. Once the mushrooms are cooked add the marsala and burn off the alcohol
6. Add the flat leaf parsley
7. Now add the cold butter and stir through before serving

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Chicken Livers

Spicy and warm with a touch of chili and smoked paprika

Ingredients

250g chicken livers
Seasoned flour for dusting (salt, pepper, paprika)
1/2 onion diced
2 cloves garlic
Dry red chili
75ml white wine
100ml cream
2 tbsp fresh chopped parsley
Olive oil
Thyme
Salt & Pepper

1. Rinse & clean the livers, then pat dry.
2. Lightly dust the livers in the seasoned flour (1 tbsp flour; 1 tsp paprika, salt & pepper to taste)
3. Add olive oil to the pan, and brown livers on med-high heat, till edges are crisped but liver still rare.
4. Remove livers and set aside, then add onion and minced garlic to the pan. Cook till softened over medium heat.
5. Now add the white wine to the pan, cook over medium high heat until wine begins to reduce.
6. Add your cream and sprinkling of thyme, now add the livers back to the pan and cook until the sauce thickens and the livers are just cooked.
7. Check and adjust seasoning and sprinkle with parsley.
8. Serve immediately with some sliced baguette

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Quick Bolognese

600g beef mince
1 Red onion, finely chopped
1 medium sized carrot, finely chopped
1-2 stalks celery, finely chopped
1 clove garlic, minced ()
1 small chilli ()
1 sprigs rosemary
1 bayleaf
1 can whole tomato ()
2 tbsp tomato paste
250ml beef stock ()
Handful of fresh chopped parsley
Olive oil
Knob of butter
Salt and Pepper

Start by adding butter and olive oil to a heavy based pot on medium/high heat

Add your finely chopped soffritto, onion, (and garlic/chilli) and cook till softened and fragrant.

Next, add your meat, bay leaf and sprig of rosemary, giving it a nice stir so that flavours are evenly distributed. At this stage, we want to brown the meat. In order to get nice caramelised meat, do not over stir. Allow a few minutes between stirring.

Once your meat is nicely browned, add your can of tomato, tomato paste and a can of water (Use your tomato can as it still has tomato in it!)

Reduce your heat to medium, pop the lid on and allow to simmer for 30 minutes - stirring occasionally. Check your seasoning

Stir through fresh chopped parsley before serving with your favourite pasta

If your mixture starts looking too dry, add a little bit of liquid (water, stock, milk) but
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